



Antwerp

The Flemish city of Antwerp rose to prominence in the 15th century as Bruges declined in importance. The world's first stock exchange was opened here in 1460 and the city became Europe's chief commercial and financial center in the 1500s, helped by the arrival of Jewish diamond craftsmen expelled from Portugal.

481–511 Under Clovis, the Franks establish a kingdom centered in what is now southern Belgium and northern France; under his successors the Frankish kingdom expands to cover most of Western Europe, reaching its apogee under Charlemagne.

889 Following several divisions, western Belgium (the county of Flanders) becomes part of the West Frankish kingdom or France, while the rest of the country (the duchy of Lower Lorraine) becomes part of the East Frankish kingdom or Germany (later the Holy Roman Empire).

1100s Feudal fragmentation leads to the rise of six main regional states: the county of Flanders in the west, the duchy of Brabant in the center, the bishopric of Liège in the east, the county of Hainault in the southwest, and the duchy of Luxembourg in the southeast. The towns of Flanders and Brabant are among the most prosperous in Europe, with wealth derived from the trade in wool.

1384 Philip the Bold, Duke of Burgundy, inherits Flanders; over the next 60 years Burgundy acquires all the other important territories in the region except for Liège, thereby creating an unprecedented degree of unity within the Low Countries.

1477 The Burgundian territories pass to the House of Habsburg.

1555–56 On the abdication of Habsburg Emperor Charles V, the Austrian and Spanish Habsburg lines are separated. The Low Countries become a province of Spain.

1567 Resistance to Spanish rule, fueled in part by the rise of Protestantism, leads to a popular revolt led by sections of the nobility and the powerful merchant class.

1579 The southern provinces (broadly speaking present-day Belgium) form the Union of Arras, reaffirming loyalty to the Habsburgs and Catholicism; the northern provinces (the future Netherlands) declare their independence from Spain in 1581.

1585 The Dutch impose a blockade on Antwerp, starting a long-term decline of the Southern Netherlands.

1648 The Treaty of Münster reaffirms Spanish rule over the Southern Netherlands.

1713 Under the Treaty of Utrecht, the Southern Netherlands are transferred to Austrian Habsburg rule.

1792–95 French and Austrian troops fight for control of the Austrian Netherlands. The territory is annexed by France.

1814–15 Congress of Vienna: European powers decide to merge Belgium with the Netherlands under King William I of Orange.

1830 Revolt against Dutch leads to the declaration of independence.

1831 European powers install Leopold Saxe Coburg as King of the Belgians

1839 Dutch recognize the independence of Belgium.

1865 Leopold II crowned king.

1884–85 Berlin Conference gives Leopold the Congo as a personal colony.

1908 After an international outcry over conditions in the Congo, the Belgian government has to take over the colony.

1909 On the death of Leopold II, his nephew succeeds as Albert I.

1914 German armies invade. Belgium occupied until 1918.

1919 Under League of Nations mandate, Belgium acquires Burundi and Rwanda.

1921 Belgo-Luxembourg Economic Union formed: Belgian and Luxembourg currencies are locked.

1934 Leopold III becomes king.

1936 Belgium declares neutrality.

1940–44 Germany occupies Belgium.

1948 Customs union with Netherlands and Luxembourg (Benelux) formed.

1950 King wins referendum on his retaining the throne, but rumors over wartime collaboration persist. In 1951 he abdicates in favor of his son, Baudouin.

1957 Signs Treaty of Rome as one of six founding members of EEC.

1992 Christian Democrat and Social Democrat government led by Jean-Luc Dehaene takes over federal government.

1980 New constitution devolves government by language: French, Flemish (Dutch), and German.

1993 Culmination of reforms creating a federal state with greater powers for regions and city governments.

1993 King Baudouin dies and is succeeded by Albert II.



End of the line

This railway station sign greeted the hundreds of thousands of troops arriving at the front in Belgium during World War I. Four major battles were fought at Ypres, including the third, Passchendaele, in 1917, with disastrous loss of life.

1995 Allegations of corruption and murder involving French-speaking Socialist Party force resignations of Walloon premier, federal deputy premier, and Willy Claes as NATO secretary general. In 1999 Claes is found guilty of bribery in connection with a defense contract.

1996 The murder of young girls arouses fears of a pedophile ring. Accusations of incompetence of authorities.

1999 New coalition government is formed, including Greens for first time, as environmental issues become important.

2009 Nine months after an indecisive general election, Yves Leterme, leader of the Flemish Christian Democrats, returns for a second term.

2010 The government collapses when Flemish liberals walk out over Francophone voting rights. Flemish separatists become the largest party in the subsequent general election.

◀150–51 Decline and Fall
◀208–09 Cities and Trade

Luxembourg



A grand duchy in western Europe with great wealth based on banking and other services.

406–07 CE An invasion by Germanic tribes ends the Roman occupation of the Rhine frontier area.

963 Luxembourg becomes an autonomous county within the Holy Roman Empire and a Duchy within the Empire from 1354.

1308–1437 The House of Luxembourg provides four Holy Roman Emperors.

1443 Luxembourg becomes one of the Burgundian lands in the Low Countries.

1477 Luxembourg passes to the Habsburgs. It is ruled by the Spanish Habsburgs from 1555 until 1713.

1713 Under the Treaty of Utrecht the southern Netherlands pass to Austrian Habsburg rule.

1815 Luxembourg becomes an independent Grand Duchy within the German Confederation, with the king of the Netherlands as head of state.

1831 Much of western (French-speaking) Luxembourg takes part in Belgian revolt against Dutch rule.

1839 The Treaty of London recognizes Belgian possession of western Luxembourg; independence of the remainder is affirmed.

1867 A congress in London confirms Luxembourg's perpetual neutrality; a Prussian garrison is withdrawn and King William III of the Netherlands is obliged to keep the Grand Duchy.

1890 Link with Dutch throne ends.

1921 Economic union with Belgium.

1940–44 German occupation.

1948 Benelux treaty creating a customs union comes into effect.

1957 Signs Treaty of Rome as one of six founding members of EEC.

1995–99 Prime Minister Jacques Santer is president of the European Commission until he is forced to resign amid corruption allegations.

2000 Grand Duke Jean abdicates in favor of his son, Henri.

2002 Euro introduced.

2008 The role of the monarchy is reduced to a ceremonial one after an attempt by Grand Duke Henri to block a bill legalizing euthanasia.

◀262–63 The 30 Years War